

“The future is SaaS plus open source”

Jina AI provides cloud-native neural search solutions powered by state-of-the-art AI technology. The company says its neural search framework called Jina empowers anyone to build SOTA and scalable neural search applications in minutes. In a conversation with **Abhinaya Kuzhanthaivel, Pradeep Sharma, senior developer relations expert, Jina AI**, touches upon his open source journey, the range of skills needed in this industry, the challenges in the open source world, how open source helps to speed up project development, and more.

Pradeep Sharma, >>
senior developer relations expert, Jina AI



Q. Can you tell us a bit about yourself and why you chose to work on open source projects?

A. I am working with Jina AI, the cloud native neural search solutions provider, as a developer relations expert for building relationships with the developers of our open source projects.

I graduated from IIT Roorkee in 2012 as an electronics and communications engineer, and always had a keen interest in programming. I joined a FinTech startup as a software engineer and built a lot of projects there. When one of my projects worked really well, I built my own startup and worked in it for about two years. But then I decided to shut it down and work for developers, especially those from remote rural areas. I could see that people from Tier II and Tier III cities do not get the kind of opportunities people in metro cities get. I started building a community of such people in 2016, which now numbers 15,000. While programming was my prime skill, I had to develop many more skills like communicating with the target audience as well as some skills in sales that could help me run an organisation.

Q. Is Jina AI your first venture into open source?

A. No. I built my own open source project back in 2016-17. I started teaching people about JSON Web Token (JWT) and what is JSON Web authentication. I did this through interactive demos. I started this developer community, and then we needed a package for encrypting some of our data. So I created an NPM package and published it on GitHub.

I had organised an online conference called the Git Commit Show in the pre-Covid days. I open sourced all the tools we had used to organise that online conference, and got a huge response from the audience. That built my confidence and indicated that open source is a great way to engage and collaborate with developers.

Q. What is meant by neural search?

A. When you search for something on Google with a keyword, it will probably give you results based on that or something similar to it. But searching by keywords is not the only way.

We use neural networks to do a semantic search, which makes your experience so much better. It doesn't matter what you provide – keywords, images or videos — it will give all the relevant results. This search is based on the examples you provide, and it learns from that. So the next time you search for something, it will just look into the repository that you have built to give you the results.

Q. What are the challenges you have faced in your open source journey?

A. Courage is needed to be more open and transparent, and to share your code with people. One also needs a change in mindset and loads of confidence. I often felt that my code may not be perfect, and was not sure if I should share it with people. There is also a fear about how secure the code is.

However, when I had organised an open source event, people like Daniel Stenberg and Sir Tim Berners-Lee encouraged me to just go ahead and open source the code, since people would support the project and also point out vulnerabilities and help to fix